

CHILDREN'S LITERATURE



WRITTEN LITERATURE has existed for more than 3,000 years, but it is only in the last 300 years that literature has been created especially for children. Before then, children listened to oral fables and folk tales. Early children's books were educational, but in the 19th century many new forms, or genres, developed such as adventure and fantasy stories, and picture books.

Books

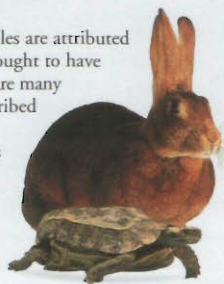
Children's books are produced in more styles, shapes, and sizes than any other form of literature. They range from pop-up books to picture books and novels. Books for younger readers have large type, and use pictures to help explain the story. As readers get older, their books become longer and the stories more complex.

Fables

A short story which illustrates a moral or lesson is called a fable. Fables usually feature animals with human characteristics, such as wisdom or carelessness, and have traditionally been read or told to children in order to encourage good behaviour. A fable may, therefore, end with a proverb such as "look before you leap".

Aesop's Fables

The most famous collection of fables are attributed to a Greek called Aesop who is thought to have lived in the 6th century BC. There are many stories about him; he is often described as a slave who gained freedom to become a royal adviser. The stories attributed to Aesop were first passed on orally, then written down in the 4th century BC.



The *Tortoise and the Hare* is one of Aesop's most famous fables.

Modern fables

Some modern children's stories have been strongly influenced by ancient fables. English author Beatrix Potter (1866–1943) wrote a story about a squirrel called Nutkin whose naughty behaviour ended in punishment.



Uncle Remus

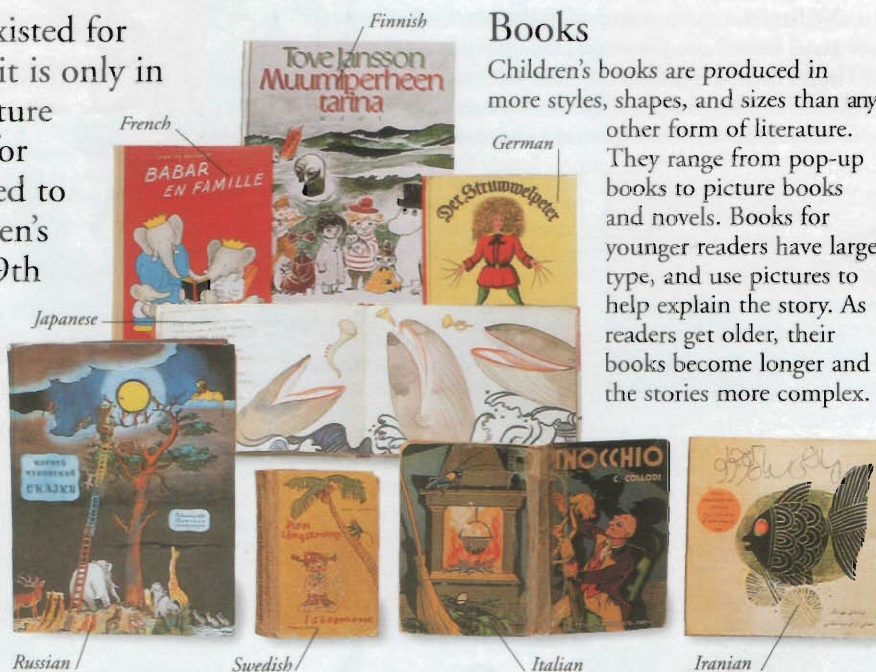
The *Uncle Remus* stories by American author Joel Chandler Harris (1848–1908) are fables based on the stories of plantation slaves in the United States. Told in African-American dialect, the tales are narrated by a wise, genial black man to the son of a plantation owner, and feature characters such as the trickster Brer Rabbit.

Brer Rabbit and Brer Fox



James Thurber (1894–1961)

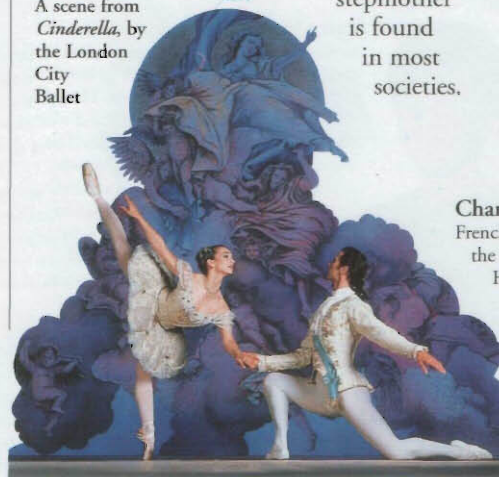
In *Fables for Our Time* (1940), American author James Thurber reworked traditional stories, such as fairy tales, into fables that were relevant to the 20th century. For example, in Thurber's reworking of the tale of *Little Red Riding Hood*, the girl recognizes the wolf and shoots him dead.



Folk and fairy tales

These are among the most popular types of stories, particularly for young children. All cultures have created their own stories about magical beings and events, and the same folk story may occur in many places. For instance, the tale of an orphaned girl with a wicked

A scene from *Cinderella*, by the London City Ballet



stepmother is found in most societies.

An illustration from Andersen's *The Snow Queen*



Hans

Christian Andersen

Danish writer Hans Christian Andersen (1805–75) was one of the first authors to write new fairy tales. His first collection, *Fairy Tales*, was published in 1835. By the time of his death, he had published more than 160 stories; most of them, such as *The Ugly Duckling*, are still read today.

Charles Perrault

Frenchman Charles Perrault (1628–1703) was the first person to write down oral folk tales. His *Tales of Past Times* (1697) included *Cinderella*, but his version was less violent and bloody than the original.

Brothers Grimm

German brothers Jakob (1785–1863) and Wilhelm (1786–1859) Grimm were the editors of *Grimm's Fairy Tales*, which included *Snow White*, and *Hansel and Gretel*. Their scholarly approach to collecting folk tales from Europe means that their versions of these ancient tales are often seen as the definitive versions.



Wilhelm Grimm



Jakob Grimm

Monkey King

The daring Monkey King is one of the best known folk heroes in Chinese literature. The Chinese writer Wu Cheng'en used many oral folk tales as source material in his novel about the Monkey King's adventures, *Journey to the West* (1500s).



Monkey battles with the White-Bone Demon